undergoing together with you, when everything has been made combat-ready," wrote Khrushchev. "After all, the American airplane committing the violation might very well be taken for a nuclear-armed bomber, and that might prompt us to take a fateful step."

That was a stretch: confusing a U-2 with a bomber was a virtual impossibility, but the recent flight of Captain Charles Maultsby had caused Kennedy and McNamara themselves to consider that the Soviets might have taken his inadvertent violation of their airspace as a last prestrike reconnaissance flight. Khrushchev never mentioned the downing of Anderson's U-2 over Cuba, but the passages of his letter on the American violation of Cuban airspace following his description of the Maultsby episode were clearly intended to provide justification for the Soviet action. "I would ask you, Mr. President, to consider that the violation of Cuban airspace by American airplanes may also have unfortunate consequences. And if you do not want this, then it would be best to avoid causing occasions for a dangerous situation to arise," wrote Khrushchev.[20]

The letter to Kennedy was accompanied by two additional messages. The first was cabled by Gromyko to Dobrynin, as discussed above, instructing him to inform the Kennedys that a positive response was coming. The second, prepared either at the same time as the main letter or soon thereafter, was supposed to be passed secretly by Dobrynin to Robert Kennedy. It concerned the confidential proposal to swap Soviet missiles in Cuba for American ones in Turkey. Khrushchev wrote: "I agree that our discussion of this subject be pursued confidentially through Robert Kennedy and the Soviet Ambassador in Washington. You may have noticed that in my message to you on October 28, which was to be published immediately, I did not raise this question—precisely because I was mindful of your wish conveyed through Robert Kennedy. But all the proposals that I presented in that message took into account the fact that you had agreed to resolve the matter of your missile bases in Turkey consistent with what I had said in my message of October 27 and what you stated through Robert Kennedy in his meeting with Ambassador Dobrynin on the same day."[21]

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